

company to say yes or no.” His insurance company said no. Scott had to choose: pay or likely die. It seems like a real version of the *Purge* films, a series of dystopian horror thrillers that I love. In the *Purge* universe, citizens of a future America are given twelve hours of one day a year to commit any crime they want without repercussions. All the people who die in the *Purge* are those who can’t afford the protections—like my friend Scott. If you’re wealthy, you live; if you’re not wealthy, you die. The scariest part of this dystopia is how similar it is to our present day.

Scott got the shot, and he got better.

After beating cancer, and now in “insurmountable debt,” he went back to his day job to pay for his treatments and daily essentials. The short-term disability payments offered by his company were running out. Four months later, he broke down in a panic. “It was just way too much to take on all at once,” he said.

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One current trend is crowdfunding your medical expenses. What was once for donors to support the arts has been co-opted for a really smart, really dark purpose.

When YouTuber Akilah Hughes was diagnosed with huge (ultimately benign) liver tumors that had to be taken out, she turned to the Internet for help. The tumors were unexpected, and for a long time, they had gone undiagnosed. Hughes became sick and unable to work and didn’t know why. She’d also accidentally let her insurance lapse and didn’t realize that until she was already in need of dire medical care. When she found out she needed an expensive surgery, she turned to GoFundMe. It sounds like an episode of *Black Mirror* in which a popular Internet personality has to prove just how beloved she really is by asking her fans to literally save her life.

There’s not a lot of hope for health care to get better under our current government, but it’s also never been that great. The Affordable Care Act (ACA or Obamacare) was certainly helpful. In both 2014 and 2017, the *New York Times* did rundowns of how the ACA was working and found that more people were insured under it. You can find countless stories online about people who